

Session 17: The Powers in the Hebrew Scriptures

Key Takeaways

- The concept of the powers is first found in Genesis 1:17 with the delegation of rule to spiritual beings.
- In the Hebrew Bible, Israel is presented as a people group under the direct power and authority of God the creator rather than other cosmic rulers.
- When humanity is freed from slavery to the powers, there is no longer male or female, slave or free, Jew or Greek. They become a people whose identities and destinies are no longer governed by the powers.

The Hebrew Bible Roots of the Powers Concept

The Hebrew Bible and Second Temple Judaism contain the roots for the concept of the powers. Paul is continuing a long scriptural tradition of seeing Heaven and Earth as overlapping parallel realms (three-tiered cosmos) and humanity as enslaved to supra-human powers that influence societies and communities.

- “The host of heaven” whom God appoints to rule the order of time ([Gen. 1](#); [Job 38:6-7](#))

Genesis 1:14-18 NASB*

¹⁴ Then God said, “Let there be lights in the dome of the skies to separate the day from the night, and let them be for signs and for seasons and for days and years; ¹⁵ and let them be for lights in the expanse of the heavens to give light on the earth”; and it was so. ¹⁶ God made two great lights, the greater light **to rule the day**, and the lesser light **to rule the night**; and the stars. ¹⁷ God placed them in the expanse of the heavens to give light on the earth, ¹⁸ and **to rule the day and the night**, and to separate the light from the darkness.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 2:1 Instructor's Translation

Thus the skies and the land were completed, with **all of their hosts**.

Psalms 136:7-9 NASB*

⁷ To him who made great lights,
for his lovingkindness is everlasting:

⁸ The sun **to rule [ἐξουσιαν] the day**,
for his lovingkindness is everlasting,

⁹ The moon and stars **to rule [ἐξουσιαν] the night**,
for his lovingkindness is everlasting.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

- The rebel cherub snake (Gen. 3; Ezek. 28)
- The rebel sons of *elohim* (Gen. 6)
- The rebellion of Babylon and the scattering of the nations (Gen. 11; Deut. 4:19-20, 32:7-8; Ps. 82; Isa. 14)

Deuteronomy 4:19-20 Instructor's Translation

¹⁹ So that you don't lift your eyes to the heavens and see **the sun and the moon and the stars, all the hosts of the heavens**, and be **led astray and worship them and serve them**, the ones whom Yahweh your God designated for all the nations under the heavens. ²⁰ But you, Yahweh has taken and he brought you out of the iron furnace of Egypt, to be a people-inheritance for himself.

Deuteronomy 32:7-8 NASB*

⁷ Remember the days of old,
understand the years of past generations. ...
⁸ When Yahweh gave the nations their inheritances,
when he divided up the sons of humanity,
he established the boundaries of the peoples,
according to the number of the sons of the gods.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalms 82:1, 6-8 Instructor's Translation

¹ God stands in the divine council,
in the midst of the gods he brings justice. ...
⁶ I had said, "Y'all are gods,
and all of you are sons of the Most High.
⁷ But on the contrary, y'all will die like humans
and like one of the rulers, y'all will fall."
⁸ Arise, O God, judge the land,
for you will inherit all the nations.

"This [idea in Deuteronomy] ... did justice to the reality of pagan religion and pagan political power with which religion was inseparably associated. It was a common phenomenon in the ancient world for a deity to be the personification of the state over which he [or she] presided. Under the successive domination of Babylon, Persia, Greece, and Rome, Israel was to have ample opportunity to discover that the pagan empires, whether they were symbolized by their earthly kings or by their heavenly guardians, were a power to be reckoned with ... This teaching [in Deuteronomy] asserted that all authority ... comes ultimately from the one God of Israel. Without some such teaching, it would have been all too easy for the pious Israelite to assume that the Gentile nations lay outside the sphere of God's kingly rule. In essence, therefore, the belief in national angels was a courageous proclamation of the universal sovereignty of God ... the Jews never really doubted that Gentile authority was derived from the Lord of all majesty and might, and that their pagan oppressors had no power over them except what was given them from above."

Caird, G. B. (2003). [*Principalities and Powers: A Study in Pauline Theology*](#). Wipf and Stock Publishers. 6-7.

In the Exodus, Psalms, and the Prophets

The exodus was both a liberation from slavery to Egypt and a defeat of its *elohim* (Exod. 12:12, 15:11).

Exodus 12:12 Instructor's Translation

And I will pass through the land of Egypt on that night, and I will strike all the firstborn of the land of Egypt, from human to beast, and **I will bring acts of justice upon all the gods of Egypt.**

Exodus 15:11 NASB*

Who is like you among the gods, Yahweh?
Who is like you, majestic in separateness,
feared in praises, doing wonders?

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The subordinated *elohim* are obligated to give honor to Yahweh.

Psalms 89:6-7 Instructor's Translation

⁶ Who in the heavens can be compared to Yahweh?
Who is like Yahweh among the sons of God,
⁷ a God feared in the assembly of the holy ones,
great and feared above all who surround him?

Psalms 29:1 Instructor's Translation

Give to Yahweh, O sons of God,
give to Yahweh glory and strength.

The past exodus anticipates a new exodus where God's people will be rescued from the curse of the covenant and enslavement to the spiritual powers that will be destroyed just like Egypt and its gods.

Isaiah 24:21-23 Instructor's Translation

²¹ And it will come about in that day,
Yahweh will bring judgment against the host of the heights on high
and against the kings of the land upon the land.
²² And prisoners are gathered over the pit,
and shut up in the prison,
and after many days they will be judged.
²³ And the moon will be ashamed,
and the sun subject to humiliation,
for Yahweh of hosts reigns as king
on Mount Zion and in Jerusalem,
and before his elders, glory!

Isaiah 27:1 Instructor's Translation

In that day, Yahweh will bring,
with his harsh and great and strong sword,
against Leviathan, the speedy snake,

against Leviathan, the twisting snake
and he will slay the sea-dragon who is in the sea.

Isaiah 34:2, 4 NASB*

² Yahweh has anger against all the nations,
and wrath against all their hosts,
he has dedicated them to destruction ...
⁴ And all the hosts [δυναμεις] of the heavens will rot,
and the skies will be rolled up as a scroll,
and all their hosts will wither,
like a leaf withers from a vine,
and like it withers from a fig tree.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Greek Translation Connection

In the Old Greek translation, these spiritual beings are called powers, rulers, authorities, etc.

Psalms 148:1-4 Septuagint/LXX

¹ Praise Yahweh ... from the heavens,
praise him among the high ones,
² praise him all his angels,
praise him all his hosts ["all his powers" δυναμεις].
³ Praise him sun, moon,
praise him all stars of light.
⁴ Praise him O heavens of the heavens,
and the waters above the heavens.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalms 103:20-21 Septuagint/LXX

²⁰ Bless Yahweh, O his angels.
Strong ones of might who do his word ...
²¹ Bless Yahweh, O all his hosts, ["all his powers" δυναμεις],
his servants who do his will.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Daniel 7:27 Septuagint/LXX

Then the rule and authority and greatness of the kingdoms under the heavens will be given to the people of the holy ones of the most high ones, and his kingdom is an eternal kingdom, and all authorities ["authorities and rulers" εξουσαι και αρχαι] will worship and serve him.

Daniel 10:13 Septuagint/LXX

And the ruler [αρχων] of Persia stood against me.

Second Temple Roots

This close connection between the celestial bodies and spiritual rulers with delegated authority over the cosmos permeates Second Temple Jewish literature.

Wisdom of Solomon 7:17-19 NRSV

¹⁷ For it is he [God] who gave me unerring knowledge of what exists, to know the structure of the world [*kosmos*] and the activity of the elements [*stoicheia*]:

¹⁸ the beginning and end and middle of times, the alternations of the solstices and the changes of the seasons [*kairoi*],

¹⁹ the cycles of the year [*eniautos*] and the constellations of the stars,

Wisdom of Solomon 13:1-3 NRSV

¹ For all people who were ignorant of God ...

² supposed that either fire or wind or swift air
or the circle of the stars, or turbulent water
or the luminaries of heaven were the gods [*theoi*] that rule the world.

³ If through delight in the beauty of these things people assumed them to be gods [*theoi*],
let them know how much better than these is their Lord,
for the author of beauty created them.

“God, being one, has about him an unspeakable number of powers, all of which are defenders and preservers of every thing that is created; Again, it is by means of these powers that the incorporeal world, perceptible by the intellect, has been put together, which is the archetypal model of this invisible world, being compounded by invisible species, just as this world is of invisible bodies. (173) Some persons therefore, admiring exceedingly the nature of both these worlds, have not only deified them in their wholes, but have also deified the most beautiful parts of them, such as the sun and the moon, and the entire heaven, which, having no reverence for anything, they have called gods. But Moses, perceiving their design, says, “O Lord, Lord, King of the gods” (Deut. 10:17) in order to show the difference between the ruler and those subject to him, (174) “And there is also in the air a most sacred company of incorporeal souls as an attendant upon the heavenly beings; for the word of prophecy is accustomed to call these souls angels. It happens therefore that the whole host of each of these worlds, being marshalled in their suitable ranks, are servants and ministers of the ruler who has marshalled them, whom they follow as their leader, in obedience to the principles of law and justice; seeing at once what is becoming, both for himself and for his works of creation, there are some things which he has entrusted to his subordinate powers to fashion; and yet he has not at once given even to them completely independent knowledge to enable it to accomplish their objects, in order that no one of those things which come to be created may be found to be erroneously made.”

Philo of Alexandria (*De Vita Contempletiva*)

“... [B]ut Moses differs from [the Gentiles] widely in their opinion of God, not intimating that either the world itself, or the soul of the world, is the original God, nor that the stars or their motions are the primary causes of the events which happen among men. Rather, Moses teaches that this universe is held together by invisible powers, which the Creator has spread from the extreme borders of the earth to heaven, making a

beautiful provision to prevent what he has joined together from being dissolved; for the indissoluble chains which bind the universe are his powers.”

Philo of Alexandria (*De Vita Contempletiva*)

“From of old you appointed the Prince of light to assist us, and in [his] ha[nd] are all the angels of [just]ice, and all the spirits of truth are under his dominion. You made Belial for the pit, angel of enmity; in dark[ness] is his [dom]ain, his counsel is to bring about wickedness and guilt. All the spirits of his lot are angels of destruction, they walk in the laws of darkness.”

Dead Sea Scrolls (4QMMT)

Reflection Question

Deuteronomy 32:8-9 can present a different way of understanding the Tower of Babel (Babylon), as well as the overall story of the Bible. What are some of your thoughts, reflections, or questions about this?